

THE WEEKEND ESSAY

We Care About Your Privacy

We, and our [229](#) partners use cookies and similar methods to recognize visitors and remember their preferences. We may also use these technologies to gauge the effectiveness of advertising campaigns, target advertisements, and analyze website traffic. Some of these technologies are essential for ensuring the proper functioning of the service or website and cannot be disabled, while others are optional but serve to enhance the user experience in various ways.

We, in collaboration with our partners, store and/or access information on a device and process your personal data, such as browsing data and device identifiers, for personalised advertising and content, advertising and content measurement, audience research and services development including by using precise geolocation data, and identification through active device scanning. You have the option to withdraw your consent or manage your preferences at any time by selecting the 'Your Privacy Choices' option located in the website footer. To review or object to instances where our partners assert a legitimate interest in utilizing your data, please visit our vendors page. Your preferences will apply only on this website.

I ACCEPT

YOUR PRIVACY CHOICES

[Privacy Policy](#)

Illustration by Jackie Carlise



Save this story



In 1953, Roald Dahl published “The Great Automatic Grammatizator,” a short story about an electrical engineer who secretly desires to be a writer. One day,

We Care About Your Privacy

We, and our partners use cookies and similar methods to recognize visitors and remember their preferences. We may also use these technologies to gauge the effectiveness of advertising campaigns, target advertisements, and analyze website traffic. Some of these technologies are essential for ensuring the proper functioning of the service or website and cannot be disabled, while others are optional but serve to enhance the user experience in various ways.

We, in collaboration with our partners, store and/or access information on a device and process your personal data, such as browsing data and device identifiers, for personalised advertising and content, advertising and content measurement, audience research and services development including by using precise geolocation data, and identification through active device scanning. You have the option to withdraw your consent or manage your preferences at any time by selecting the 'Your Privacy Choices' option located in the website footer. To review or object to instances where our partners assert a legitimate interest in utilizing your data, please visit our vendors page. Your preferences will apply only on this website.

[Privacy Policy](#)

unconsciously—making a choice about almost every word you type; to oversimplify, we can imagine that a ten-thousand-word short story requires something on the order of ten thousand choices. When you give a generative-A.I. program a prompt, you are making very few choices; if you supply a hundred-word prompt, you have made on the order of a hundred choices.

If an A.I. generates a ten-thousand-word story based on your prompt, it has to fill in for all of the choices that you are not making. There are various ways it can do this. One is to take an average of the choices that other writers have made, as represented by text found on the Internet; that average is equivalent to the least interesting choices possible, which is why A.I.-generated text is often really bland. Another is to instruct the program to engage in style mimicry, emulating the

We Care About Your Privacy

We, and our partners use cookies and similar methods to recognize visitors and remember their preferences. We may also use these technologies to gauge the effectiveness of advertising campaigns, target advertisements, and analyze website traffic. Some of these technologies are essential for ensuring the proper functioning of the service or website and cannot be disabled, while others are optional but serve to enhance the user experience in various ways.

We, in collaboration with our partners, store and/or access information on a device and process your personal data, such as browsing data and device identifiers, for personalised advertising and content, advertising and content measurement, audience research and services development including by using precise geolocation data, and identification through active device scanning. You have the option to withdraw your consent or manage your preferences at any time by selecting the 'Your Privacy Choices' option located in the website footer. To review or object to instances where our partners assert a legitimate interest in utilizing your data, please visit our vendors page. Your preferences will apply only on this website.

[Privacy Policy](#)

didn't seem like an artistic medium because it wasn't apparent that there were a lot of choices to be made; you just set up the camera and start the exposure. But over time people realized that there were a vast number of things you could do with cameras, and the artistry lies in the many choices that a photographer makes. It might not always be easy to articulate what the choices are, but when you compare

an amateur's photos to a professional's, you can see the difference. So then the question becomes: Is there a similar opportunity to make a vast number of choices using a text-to-image generator? I think the answer is no. An artist—whether working digitally or with paint—implicitly makes far more decisions during the process of making a painting than would fit into a text prompt of a few hundred words.

We Care About Your Privacy

We, and our partners use cookies and similar methods to recognize visitors and remember their preferences. We may also use these technologies to gauge the effectiveness of advertising campaigns, target advertisements, and analyze website traffic. Some of these technologies are essential for ensuring the proper functioning of the service or website and cannot be disabled, while others are optional but serve to enhance the user experience in various ways.

We, in collaboration with our partners, store and/or access information on a device and process your personal data, such as browsing data and device identifiers, for personalised advertising and content, advertising and content measurement, audience research and services development including by using precise geolocation data, and identification through active device scanning. You have the option to withdraw your consent or manage your preferences at any time by selecting the 'Your Privacy Choices' option located in the website footer. To review or object to instances where our partners assert a legitimate interest in utilizing your data, please visit our vendors page. Your preferences will apply only on this website.

[Privacy Policy](#)

novel. This hypothetical writing program might require you to enter a hundred thousand words of prompts in order for it to generate an entirely different hundred thousand words that make up the novel you're envisioning. It's not clear to me what such a program would look like. Theoretically, if such a program existed, the user could perhaps deserve to be called the author. But, again, I don't

think companies like OpenAI want to create versions of ChatGPT that require just as much effort from users as writing a novel from scratch. The selling point of generative A.I. is that these programs generate vastly more than you put into them, and that is precisely what prevents them from being effective tools for artists.

We Care About Your Privacy

We, and our partners use cookies and similar methods to recognize visitors and remember their preferences. We may also use these technologies to gauge the effectiveness of advertising campaigns, target advertisements, and analyze website traffic. Some of these technologies are essential for ensuring the proper functioning of the service or website and cannot be disabled, while others are optional but serve to enhance the user experience in various ways.

We, in collaboration with our partners, store and/or access information on a device and process your personal data, such as browsing data and device identifiers, for personalised advertising and content, advertising and content measurement, audience research and services development including by using precise geolocation data, and identification through active device scanning. You have the option to withdraw your consent or manage your preferences at any time by selecting the 'Your Privacy Choices' option located in the website footer. To review or object to instances where our partners assert a legitimate interest in utilizing your data, please visit our vendors page. Your preferences will apply only on this website.

[Privacy Policy](#)

sentences—and the small-scale choices they represent—help to determine the thriller's effectiveness.

Many novelists have had the experience of being approached by someone convinced that they have a great idea for a novel, which they are willing to share in

exchange for a fifty-fifty split of the proceeds. Such a person inadvertently reveals that they think formulating sentences is a nuisance rather than a fundamental part of storytelling in prose. Generative A.I. appeals to people who think they can express themselves in a medium without actually working in that medium. But the creators of traditional novels, paintings, and films are drawn to those art forms because they see the unique expressive potential that each medium affords. It is

We Care About Your Privacy

We, and our partners use cookies and similar methods to recognize visitors and remember their preferences. We may also use these technologies to gauge the effectiveness of advertising campaigns, target advertisements, and analyze website traffic. Some of these technologies are essential for ensuring the proper functioning of the service or website and cannot be disabled, while others are optional but serve to enhance the user experience in various ways.

We, in collaboration with our partners, store and/or access information on a device and process your personal data, such as browsing data and device identifiers, for personalised advertising and content, advertising and content measurement, audience research and services development including by using precise geolocation data, and identification through active device scanning. You have the option to withdraw your consent or manage your preferences at any time by selecting the 'Your Privacy Choices' option located in the website footer. To review or object to instances where our partners assert a legitimate interest in utilizing your data, please visit our vendors page. Your preferences will apply only on this website.

[Privacy Policy](#)

extraordinary; if the young girl had written the letter herself, it would likely have been indistinguishable from countless others. The significance of a child's fan letter—both to the child who writes it and to the athlete who receives it—comes from its being heartfelt rather than from its being eloquent.

Many of us have sent store-bought greeting cards, knowing that it will be clear to the recipient that we didn't compose the words ourselves. We don't copy the words from a Hallmark card in our own handwriting, because that would feel dishonest. The programmer Simon Willison has described the training for large language

We Care About Your Privacy

We, and our partners use cookies and similar methods to recognize visitors and remember their preferences. We may also use these technologies to gauge the effectiveness of advertising campaigns, target advertisements, and analyze website traffic. Some of these technologies are essential for ensuring the proper functioning of the service or website and cannot be disabled, while others are optional but serve to enhance the user experience in various ways.

We, in collaboration with our partners, store and/or access information on a device and process your personal data, such as browsing data and device identifiers, for personalised advertising and content, advertising and content measurement, audience research and services development including by using precise geolocation data, and identification through active device scanning. You have the option to withdraw your consent or manage your preferences at any time by selecting the 'Your Privacy Choices' option located in the website footer. To review or object to instances where our partners assert a legitimate interest in utilizing your data, please visit our vendors page. Your preferences will apply only on this website.

[Privacy Policy](#)

child, even though both lack the capability to use words. ChatGPT feels nothing and desires nothing, and this lack of intention is why ChatGPT is not actually using language. What makes the words “I’m happy to see you” a linguistic utterance is not that the sequence of text tokens that it is made up of are well formed; what makes it a linguistic utterance is the intention to communicate something.

Because language comes so easily to us, it's easy to forget that it lies on top of these other experiences of subjective feeling and of wanting to communicate that feeling. We're tempted to project those experiences onto a large language model when it emits coherent sentences, but to do so is to fall prey to mimicry; it's the same phenomenon as when butterflies evolve large dark spots on their wings that can fool birds into thinking they're predators with big eyes. There is a context in

We Care About Your Privacy

We, and our partners use cookies and similar methods to recognize visitors and remember their preferences. We may also use these technologies to gauge the effectiveness of advertising campaigns, target advertisements, and analyze website traffic. Some of these technologies are essential for ensuring the proper functioning of the service or website and cannot be disabled, while others are optional but serve to enhance the user experience in various ways.

We, in collaboration with our partners, store and/or access information on a device and process your personal data, such as browsing data and device identifiers, for personalised advertising and content, advertising and content measurement, audience research and services development including by using precise geolocation data, and identification through active device scanning. You have the option to withdraw your consent or manage your preferences at any time by selecting the 'Your Privacy Choices' option located in the website footer. To review or object to instances where our partners assert a legitimate interest in utilizing your data, please visit our vendors page. Your preferences will apply only on this website.

[Privacy Policy](#)

to strengthen students' critical-thinking skills; in the same way that lifting weights is useful no matter what sport an athlete plays, writing essays develops skills necessary for whatever job a college student will eventually get. Using ChatGPT to complete assignments is like bringing a forklift into the weight room; you will never improve your cognitive fitness that way.

Not all writing needs to be creative, or heartfelt, or even particularly good; sometimes it simply needs to exist. Such writing might support other goals, such as attracting views for advertising or satisfying bureaucratic requirements. When people are required to produce such text, we can hardly blame them for using whatever tools are available to accelerate the process. But is the world better off with more documents that have had minimal effort expended on them? It would

We Care About Your Privacy

We, and our partners use cookies and similar methods to recognize visitors and remember their preferences. We may also use these technologies to gauge the effectiveness of advertising campaigns, target advertisements, and analyze website traffic. Some of these technologies are essential for ensuring the proper functioning of the service or website and cannot be disabled, while others are optional but serve to enhance the user experience in various ways.

We, in collaboration with our partners, store and/or access information on a device and process your personal data, such as browsing data and device identifiers, for personalised advertising and content, advertising and content measurement, audience research and services development including by using precise geolocation data, and identification through active device scanning. You have the option to withdraw your consent or manage your preferences at any time by selecting the 'Your Privacy Choices' option located in the website footer. To review or object to instances where our partners assert a legitimate interest in utilizing your data, please visit our vendors page. Your preferences will apply only on this website.

[Privacy Policy](#)

gain new skills. I think this reflects our intuitions about human beings pretty well. Most people can learn a new skill given sufficient practice, but the faster the person picks up the skill, the more intelligent we think the person is. What's interesting about this definition is that—unlike I.Q. tests—it's also applicable to

nonhuman entities; when a dog learns a new trick quickly, we consider that a sign of intelligence.

In 2019, researchers conducted an experiment in which they taught rats how to drive. They put the rats in little plastic containers with three copper-wire bars; when the mice put their paws on one of these bars, the container would either go

We Care About Your Privacy

We, and our partners use cookies and similar methods to recognize visitors and remember their preferences. We may also use these technologies to gauge the effectiveness of advertising campaigns, target advertisements, and analyze website traffic. Some of these technologies are essential for ensuring the proper functioning of the service or website and cannot be disabled, while others are optional but serve to enhance the user experience in various ways.

We, in collaboration with our partners, store and/or access information on a device and process your personal data, such as browsing data and device identifiers, for personalised advertising and content, advertising and content measurement, audience research and services development including by using precise geolocation data, and identification through active device scanning. You have the option to withdraw your consent or manage your preferences at any time by selecting the 'Your Privacy Choices' option located in the website footer. To review or object to instances where our partners assert a legitimate interest in utilizing your data, please visit our vendors page. Your preferences will apply only on this website.

[Privacy Policy](#)

training data, whereas humans taking their first driving class will know to stop. More than our ability to solve algebraic equations, our ability to cope with unfamiliar situations is a fundamental part of why we consider humans intelligent. Computers will not be able to replace humans until they acquire that type of competence, and that is still a long way off; for the time being, we're just looking for jobs that can be done with turbocharged auto-complete.

Despite years of hype, the ability of generative A.I. to dramatically increase economic productivity remains theoretical. (Earlier this year, Goldman Sachs released a report titled “Gen AI: Too Much Spend, Too Little Benefit?”) The task that generative A.I. has been most successful at is lowering our expectations, both of the things we read and of ourselves when we write anything for others to read. It is a fundamentally dehumanizing technology because it treats us as less than

We Care About Your Privacy

We, and our partners use cookies and similar methods to recognize visitors and remember their preferences. We may also use these technologies to gauge the effectiveness of advertising campaigns, target advertisements, and analyze website traffic. Some of these technologies are essential for ensuring the proper functioning of the service or website and cannot be disabled, while others are optional but serve to enhance the user experience in various ways.

We, in collaboration with our partners, store and/or access information on a device and process your personal data, such as browsing data and device identifiers, for personalised advertising and content, advertising and content measurement, audience research and services development including by using precise geolocation data, and identification through active device scanning. You have the option to withdraw your consent or manage your preferences at any time by selecting the 'Your Privacy Choices' option located in the website footer. To review or object to instances where our partners assert a legitimate interest in utilizing your data, please visit our vendors page. Your preferences will apply only on this website.

[Privacy Policy](#)

all products of what has come before us, but it's by living our lives in interaction with others that we bring meaning into the world. That is something that an auto-complete algorithm can never do, and don't let anyone tell you otherwise. ♦

New Yorker Favorites

- Parents disagreed on whether to vaccinate their children. Then the kids got sick.
- Take a break with our Puzzles & Games.

We Care About Your Privacy

We, and our partners use cookies and similar methods to recognize visitors and remember their preferences. We may also use these technologies to gauge the effectiveness of advertising campaigns, target advertisements, and analyze website traffic. Some of these technologies are essential for ensuring the proper functioning of the service or website and cannot be disabled, while others are optional but serve to enhance the user experience in various ways.

We, in collaboration with our partners, store and/or access information on a device and process your personal data, such as browsing data and device identifiers, for personalised advertising and content, advertising and content measurement, audience research and services development including by using precise geolocation data, and identification through active device scanning. You have the option to withdraw your consent or manage your preferences at any time by selecting the 'Your Privacy Choices' option located in the website footer. To review or object to instances where our partners assert a legitimate interest in utilizing your data, please visit our vendors page. Your preferences will apply only on this website.

[Privacy Policy](#)

Q. & A.

How, Exactly, Could A.I. Kill Us?

Employees of A.I. companies are increasingly sounding the alarm. What should we make of their warnings?

By Tyler Foggatt

FAULT LINES

How the Job Market Will Shape the Next Generation

Young people are already discontented. It's not going to get better anytime soon.

By Jay Caspian Kang

We Care About Your Privacy

We, and our partners use cookies and similar methods to recognize visitors and remember their preferences. We may also use these technologies to gauge the effectiveness of advertising campaigns, target advertisements, and analyze website traffic. Some of these technologies are essential for ensuring the proper functioning of the service or website and cannot be disabled, while others are optional but serve to enhance the user experience in various ways.

We, in collaboration with our partners, store and/or access information on a device and process your personal data, such as browsing data and device identifiers, for personalised advertising and content, advertising and content measurement, audience research and services development including by using precise geolocation data, and identification through active device scanning. You have the option to withdraw your consent or manage your preferences at any time by selecting the 'Your Privacy Choices' option located in the website footer. To review or object to instances where our partners assert a legitimate interest in utilizing your data, please visit our vendors page. Your preferences will apply only on this website.

[Privacy Policy](#)

The Unique Horrors of A.I. Food Slop

Why does it feel so unsettling when restaurants use generative A.I. to create their menus and promotional materials?

By Brady Brickner-Wood

THE NEW YORKER INTERVIEW

Rivers Cuomo Is Piecing It All Together

The singer-songwriter and Weezer front man on the making of the band's new LP, the Gold Album, his relationship with his father, and the stories we tell about ourselves.

By Amanda Petrusich

We Care About Your Privacy

We, and our partners use cookies and similar methods to recognize visitors and remember their preferences. We may also use these technologies to gauge the effectiveness of advertising campaigns, target advertisements, and analyze website traffic. Some of these technologies are essential for ensuring the proper functioning of the service or website and cannot be disabled, while others are optional but serve to enhance the user experience in various ways.

We, in collaboration with our partners, store and/or access information on a device and process your personal data, such as browsing data and device identifiers, for personalised advertising and content, advertising and content measurement, audience research and services development including by using precise geolocation data, and identification through active device scanning. You have the option to withdraw your consent or manage your preferences at any time by selecting the 'Your Privacy Choices' option located in the website footer. To review or object to instances where our partners assert a legitimate interest in utilizing your data, please visit our vendors page. Your preferences will apply only on this website.

[Privacy Policy](#)

THE WEEKEND ESSAY

Should the Classroom Be More Like the Gym?

As A.I. presses harder on the academic enterprise, we might look to a place where process is its own reward.

By Dan Rockmore

BOOKS

The Art of American Sophistication

How striving, self-invention, and charm became a national style.

By Adam Gopnik

We Care About Your Privacy

We, and our partners use cookies and similar methods to recognize visitors and remember their preferences. We may also use these technologies to gauge the effectiveness of advertising campaigns, target advertisements, and analyze website traffic. Some of these technologies are essential for ensuring the proper functioning of the service or website and cannot be disabled, while others are optional but serve to enhance the user experience in various ways.

We, in collaboration with our partners, store and/or access information on a device and process your personal data, such as browsing data and device identifiers, for personalised advertising and content, advertising and content measurement, audience research and services development including by using precise geolocation data, and identification through active device scanning. You have the option to withdraw your consent or manage your preferences at any time by selecting the 'Your Privacy Choices' option located in the website footer. To review or object to instances where our partners assert a legitimate interest in utilizing your data, please visit our vendors page. Your preferences will apply only on this website.

[Privacy Policy](#)